Eight Questions Families Ask When They Start to Wonder Whether Dad's Days Are Changing

Plain answers about what to write down, and which questions belong with a professional.

You're not sure whether you're noticing something about Dad or reading too much into one afternoon. Plenty of families have stood in the same spot. These are the questions they ask, answered in general terms.

The answers are general on purpose. Anything that depends on Dad himself is marked with who to take it to.

1 Nothing is wrong. Why write anything down?

So that later there's something to compare with. A baseline is a dated description of an ordinary week: what Dad does on his own and where he already gets a hand. It doesn't claim anything is wrong, and nothing needs to be for it to be useful.

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** something about his health concerns you today. That's a conversation with his doctor, not a note for the file.

2 What does an ordinary week look like for him now, and how do we describe it?

Go through everyday life one activity at a time. The federal Administration for Community Living lists the basic personal tasks as bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence and eating, and the everyday tasks as housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing meals, shopping, using the telephone, caring for pets and responding to emergency alerts. For each, note what Dad does on his own and where someone lends a hand. Where you haven't seen, write “not noted.” [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're not sure how to describe something you saw. Say what happened in plain words, and they'll ask what they need to know.

3 How do we tell whether the family is helping more than it used to?

List everything anyone does for him, with roughly when each thing began. AARP's planning guide notes that caregiving may start with driving a loved one to get groceries or to the doctor, and later include preparing meals or handling bills. Each addition is small, which is why it goes uncounted. It's also ordinary: about 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers. [2] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the list is longer than you expected and you'd like to talk through what it shows. That's a conversation for his doctor or your care consultant.

4 What changes should prompt a conversation with a professional?

No guide can answer that for Dad. Which changes matter depends on his health and his history, and the people who know those are his doctor and the other professionals he sees. What the family can do is write each change down as a specific thing that happened, with its date, and ask at an ordinary appointment what they'd want to hear about between visits. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've noticed a change and wonder whether it's worth mentioning. Mention it. Judging whether it matters is their part.

5 Should Dad be part of this, or do we keep notes quietly?

He comes first. AARP's guide says a family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and should never be made without their participation, knowledge and consent. Ask him what's easy, what takes longer and where a hand is welcome, and write his account in his own words. Then add what the family has seen, marked as yours. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** his account and the family's differ and you can't see why. Bring both. Settling it isn't the family's job.

6 I noticed one thing last weekend. Does it mean something?

One thing is one thing. Write what happened and the date, and keep that apart from what you made of it: “he missed Thursday's appointment” is a note, and a conclusion about his memory isn't. Professionals are asked to look at the usual pattern too; the form home health clinicians complete tells them to record a person's usual performance. Whether a single event matters is for someone who assesses him to say. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** one note in particular stays on your mind. Take it, with its date, to his doctor.

7 What about his medicines? Should we be checking them?

Keep a current list, and keep your questions on a separate one. The Family Caregiver Alliance advises an updated list of all medicines, including prescription drugs, over-the-counter medicines, vitamins, other nutritional products and herbal remedies, shared with his doctors. If something about a medicine concerns you, its advice is to contact the primary care provider and the pharmacist before anything is adjusted. The family's part is the list and the questions, never the changes. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you have any question about what he takes or how he takes it. That goes to his pharmacist or the prescriber.

8 How often should we come back to the page?

Nothing here sets a schedule. As a point of comparison, the CDC suggests families update a written care plan, its name for a form summarizing a person's health conditions, care needs and current treatments, every year, or more often after a change in health or medicines. When Dad himself should be assessed again is a separate question, and it belongs to his doctor and the other professionals who know him. [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know when he should be looked at again. That's theirs to tell you.

What this guide doesn't do

Nothing here is an answer about Dad himself. Whether a change matters, what it means and when he should be looked at again need someone who knows his health.

Ready for the next step?

You have general answers, and a sense of which questions belong with a professional. The care interview does the part about Dad: it goes through his daily life area by area, records each answer with its source and date, and builds a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiver's Guide to Medications and Aging
5. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Outcome and Assessment Information Set Version E1 (OASIS-E1), All Items
6. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.